

Indus Valley Civilization: Sites, Urban Culture & Decline

Map-ready sites, urban planning, crafts/trade, and decline theories UPSC recycles every few years.

Portion focus ~42% · Topic: hist-ancient

PYQ themes: IVC sites & features · Harappan crafts & trade · Decline theories · Urban planning

Why UPSC asks this

IVC lets examiners test map memory, feature–site matching, and comparative civilisation logic without endless dynastic lists. Sites like Lothal, Dholavira and Rakhigarhi recur because they carry distinctive archaeological signatures.

Why this portion scores for Prelims

Ancient India as a whole sits near ~39% next-exam chance in this hub's PYQ model, but within that block the examiner's favourite slices are IVC sites, Buddhism–Jainism, and Maurya–Gupta culture. IVC questions are almost never “name every king”; they are matching lists (site !” feature), statements on urban traits, or trade/decline options. Treat this as a map + feature bank, not a narrative romance of “mysterious Indus”.

Urban morphology you must visualise

Mature Harappan towns typically show planned streets (often approximate grid), standardised baked bricks, elaborate drainage, and a bipartite layout: an elevated citadel (public/ritual/elite structures) and a lower town (housing, craft). The Great Bath at Mohenjo-daro remains the classic public-water structure in textbooks; granaries/warehouse complexes appear at Harappa and related sites. Uniform weights and measures and careful brick ratios signal administrative coordination even without readable texts. For Prelims, link “covered drains + soak pits” to civic hygiene planning — a frequent statement trap when options claim Harappans lacked urban civic sense.

Economy, crafts and long-distance links

Craft specialisation is a PYQ magnet: bead-making (Lothal, Chanhudaro), shell working, metallurgy (copper/bronze), and steatite seals. Agriculture supported cities with wheat, barley and (in some zones) other crops; cattle, sheep/goat and, at some sites, horse evidence remains debated — do not overclaim. Trade stretched inland and overseas: Mesopotamian texts refer to Meluhha (often linked to Indus), while Lothal's dockyard anchors the maritime narrative for Gujarat. Seals and sealings imply accounting/identity functions. Remember: script is undeciphered, so “Harappan religion” reconstructions (Pashupati seal, mother goddess figurines, sacred trees) stay interpretive — UPSC may ask what is attested archaeologically versus what is speculation.

Site–feature pairs (exam gold)

Drill these until instant: Lothal–dockyard; Dholavira–reservoirs/water harvesting and unique three-part division; Kalibangan–ploughed field evidence and ritual fire altars; Mohenjo-daro–Great Bath; Harappa–granaries; Rakhigarhi–scale of settlement in India; Surkotada–often cited in horse-bone debates (handle carefully). Eastern fringe (Alamgirpur on Hindon) shows Harappan cultural reach into the Ganga–Yamuna doab margins. When a question gives four sites and four features, eliminate by uniqueness first (dockyard almost always Lothal).

Decline without dogma

Mature Harappan urbanism wanes into Late Harappan patterns. Leading explanations include aridification/climate stress, shifting river courses (e.g., Ghaggar–Hakra debates), ecological strain, and disruption of long-distance trade — usually in combination. Invasion theories as a sole cause are outdated for serious prep. For Mains/Prelims statements: prefer multi-causal language. Also separate “decline of cities” from “disappearance of people” — rural and regional continuities matter.

Previous-year angle

UPSC repeatedly returns to distinctive site features and comparative civilisation statements (urban vs Vedic pastoral/early agrarian). Expect assertion–reason style traps that smuggle Vedic ritual into Harappan archaeology. Your edge is precise pairing and refusal of romantic single theories.

Map / list facts

- Harappa (Punjab, Pakistan) — granaries, cemetery H
- Mohenjo-daro (Sindh) — Great Bath, citadel–lower town
- Dholavira (Kutch, Gujarat) — reservoirs, three-part city, signboard
- Lothal (Gujarat) — dockyard, bead factory, Persian Gulf trade link

- Kalibangan (Rajasthan) — ploughed field, fire altars
- Rakhigarhi (Haryana) — among largest Harappan settlements in India
- Banawali, Surkotada, Chanhudaro, Alamgirpur — craft/animal/eastern fringe markers

Must remember

- Grid planning, baked bricks, covered drains, citadel vs lower town
- Undeciphered script; seals with unicorn motif & Indus signs
- Lothal = dockyard; Dholavira = water systems; Kalibangan = ploughed field
- Do NOT equate IVC with Vedic culture (different chronology, ritual, urban profile)
- Decline: multi-causal (climate, river shift, trade disruption) — avoid single-cause absolutism

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